

STARS



Muthiah Muralidharan

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only one media rights bid for IPL, with the second bid from ESS, rumoured to be below the floor price of Rs 236 crore per year, not being opened due to certain conditions placed by the channel. WSG CEO (South Asia) Venu Nair confirmed that the South Asia telecast deal with Sony ran for five, not 10 years, and that WSG had retained the

global, web, mobile and radio rights.

It is not as if IPL has been handed over a billion-dollar cheque. Under the terms of the media deal, of a total of the Rs 3,672 crore, WSG's payout will involve a payment of only Rs 1,400-crore-plus over the first five years with the balance over the next five. Sony is also contracted to spend Rs 432 crore on IPL 'promotion', the figure taking the deal over the desired \$1 billion mark; these 'promotions' though could involve low cost in-house advertising.

Q WHO HAS THE LAST LAUGH?

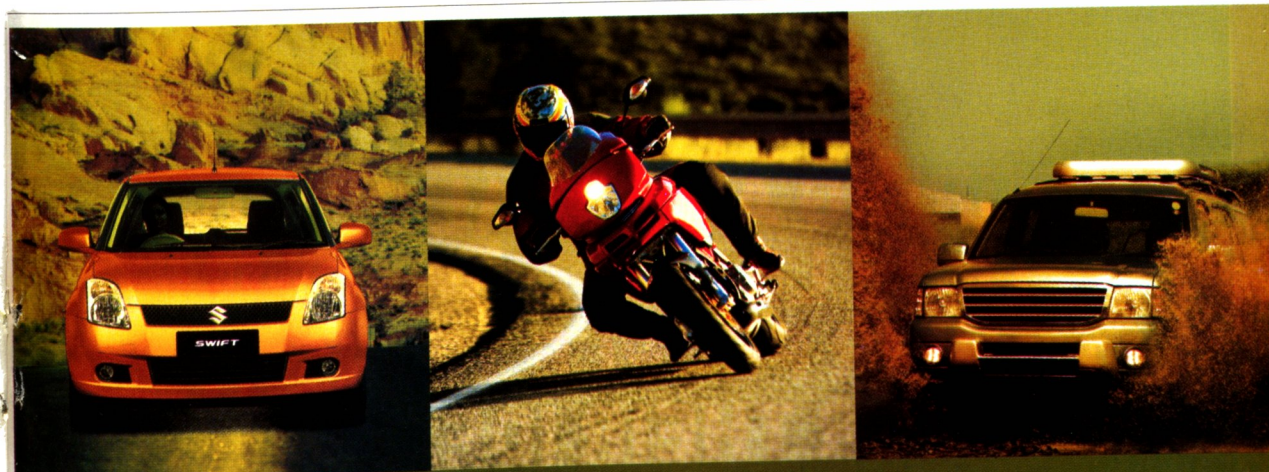
Yes, it's them again. BCCI. To start out with, every franchise will cough up a franchise fee of Rs 36 crore up front and of this total sum of Rs 288 crore, 70 per cent or approximately Rs 208 crore will be distributed amongst BCCI's state associations, each of whom could pocket a cool Rs 10 crore. BCCI Chief Administrative Officer Ratnakar Shetty

says, "IPL will benefit not only the associations, it will generate jobs for former players and lead to an upgradation of grounds." BCCI's state bodies range from the efficient to the notoriously-corrupt and so the trickledown effect of this financial windfall may not be as widespread or even as wholesome as optimists like Shetty believe.

The playing community in Indian cricket is lined up behind the idea but some need to see a little execution first. "Conceptually, it is impressive, but we need to see the show on the road to understand how it's going to grow and what effect it will have on domestic cricket," says former Test batsman-turned-commentator Sanjay Manjrekar.

IPL's parent franchise model is imported from Europe and the United States where issues like turnstiles, numbered seating and piracy control on merchandise are given. Adapting this to Indian cricket with its culture of poor spectator facilities, the complimentary pass, merchandise rip-offs will be an exercise that will strip this grand plan of its claims and force it to show proof of real life and real change.

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